# Camille Thomas's Feedback

**CAMILLE THOMAS (0:00):** Up and. IPhone. Can you hear me? I hear you.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (0:33):** Okay.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (0:33):** Speak.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (0:35):** All right.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (0:37):** Hey. And I see you.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (0:40):** Okay. Yeah. I'm at Asia Society and, like, things just got delayed, like, hard. But I'm. I'm here. Like, my super nose. Yeah. Everything is just like. People just put the wrong things on a. What you say? Fire coat hazard. So I had to move everything, but that's beside the point. I'm here to listen also. Thank you so much. How are you?

**CAMILLE THOMAS (1:06):** I am doing well. I'm a little tired today. I go teach later. I'm only teaching one class and it's only for an hour, and it's down at, like, New York Public Library, but that's not until 5, so I'm trying to, like, get some work done and do some reading and some writing before that. How are you?

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (1:24):** I'm good. Yes. It's busy season this month and I'm just gonna push all work this month and then try to enjoy November. Yeah, it's been good reconnecting with so many people for this, but, yeah, healing through music. I frankly didn't like, write music for. Until. For like, nearly a year until a July project and then this project, really. So. Yeah. Thank you so much for taking the time to read it. Yeah. Like, I don't know. What's your thoughts?

**CAMILLE THOMAS (2:05):** Yeah, no, it was so heartfelt. I thought this was really beautiful and timely and definitely something a lot of people will need as we are facing the poly crisis. So many crisis of like, mental health and sort of AI and data centers and just people trying to figure out a way through.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (2:27):** Yes. Yeah. No, I. It frankly was like, when I was. I always wanted to write something called Michigan, but I didn't know what it's about for years. I was gonna, like, personify Great Lakes and just like, hey, here's a fan. Five family members of five. They're Superior, Huron, Yuri.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (2:50):** It's fun.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (2:51):** Michigan and Ontario. Yes. Or America now, but like, no.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (2:57):** No, it's not.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (2:58):** Yeah, yeah. Like, I. That was for a while, but a million things of course happened. And you know what happened? And it's like my brain just started working, I guess.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (3:10):** And.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (3:10):** Yeah, no, I just. Like, when I was turning 30 with Y', all, I was kind of like, how do I challenge myself in a different way? So this is like my first truly fully human musical. So I thought it was gonna be really hard, like, because I was like, dang, I don't have the filter of a personifying something. It's just like, oh, yeah. It's telling me about yeah, like telling my life, but I personify it, so it's a little goofy. And I'm like, I'm able to write, but because I named a lot of these characters specific elemental names, I was like, okay, it's coming easier to me.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (3:49):** Yeah, yeah, I love. I guess I had some questions, like, I have. It's been a little bit since I've read it, but I'm looking at my notes at least one of the things that I remember thinking. Petey's decision to kill himself seemed very sudden. I know he was dealing with the layoff from the automotive industry and everything, but in addition to that, I was curious of, like, did he also struggle with depression or some sort of mental health disorder?

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (4:17):** Yeah, yeah, no, that's a good point. Actually, I should note that. Yeah. Like, I've considered like, trying to write a prequel to fix to figure that out a little bit. Like, oh, yeah, they. Lizzie and Petey met probably a residency in high school and. Or Mackinac island, making. Making Mackinac Island a very important thing. And that's where maybe hints of Petey's mental health was. Yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah. Like, obviously. Yeah. Engineers or anyone who are very science minded, very full of mental illness, quote, unquote. So that I still, like, don't want to be so general about it. I should figure out, like, what specific ones you possibly have that's under the umbrella of depression. Definitely. Besides the automotive industry. Yeah. There's like a flashback where. Yeah. Like, he gets in a fight with his little sister Shelby, because. Yeah, he's. I. I did plant that. He's kind of racist, like, against Middle Easterners.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (5:29):** Yeah.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (5:31):** So. And during the fight, like, Lizzie throws away her wedding ring. So it's kind of like that also triggered it to him.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (5:40):** Okay. If you're looking for like a mental health disorder, to be specific with it could. This is a suggestion. Take it or leave it. It could be dysthymia, which is

like a minor. Minor is a big word, but, like consistent. Sort of like a low grade depression. And I know my brother has dysthymia. I'll type it in the chat. Yeah, it's. It's now called persistent depressive disorder. But it used to be called. I'm just googled it. It used to be called dysthymia, a chronic long term form of depression, blah, blah, blah. But yeah, if you're looking for like, A prescriptive idea.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (6:10):** Yes, please. Yes. Oh, okay. This is great. Yeah. Because if I want to answer questions during talk back like that, it's like, okay, here's some things I throw. And I have researched her. Yeah. That mental health might be. Might be. Frankly, the least I did only because I struggle with mental health, with myself. So we're like, all of us. But definitely, like, right? Yeah. Like, writing music for this was like, I had to have a friend, like, on call at 4 in the morning. Like, hey. Yeah. Especially like, with his suicide body water. I wrote it, like by the water constantly. And then in the middle of night when I'm saddest lonely to trigger that. But it does like, like, you. You as an artist probably have to sink really low to get to these points.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (7:01):** Like, hey. Yeah. Good art. I mean, good art heals and reveals. I'll say that. Reveals and heals. Yeah.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (7:27):** Yes. It's. I. I'm trying to make it heal me more than it reveals.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (7:35):** Yeah. Yeah, we gotta get to that. We gotta get to that. That's the goal.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (7:39):** Yes. Okay, that's good. And then that helps because with Petoskey too, growing up without a father, I try to show that Petoskey is doing the same mistakes as Petey. And like, Lizzie is seeing that. And then Lizzie is like, oh, no. The worst of Petey is also in Petoskey. But also, in the end, he learned, like, she knows, like, the best of him was. Is also in Petoskey. And he's also an original person. But, like. Yeah. So I. I guess what would you do? Diving into, like, fodderless children. Yeah. If you. Yeah. Were those resources. Because I have a full family. Like.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (8:24):** Yeah. You're like. Yeah, I guess I would talk to folks maybe who are missing their fathers. I also have a full family. But I'm just curious. A question that I like to ask my friends, honestly, is how are you most like your parents and how are you most. Least like your parents? How are you least like your parents? And then thinking of the things that my father gave me and what the absences would be if I did not have those and what the curiosities would be like for me. Yeah. My dad is a very creative person. And my mom does not have a creative bone in her body, bless her. But I know if I did not have my dad in my life, I think I would really struggle with why do I have all these big emotions? Like, and my dad is like a big emotion guy and my mom is, like, pretty stable. So I think discovering

what Petey has from his mother and what he has from his father. And maybe he can question those things about, like, why am I always sad if it's whatever things he has from his father, why am I always angry? Or why do I love water and my mom doesn't love water? You know?

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (9:34):** Yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah. That helps. Okay. There probably are resources that help map that out a bit too. Like, not. Not just a Venn diagram. Like, okay, this is. But Venn diagram probably help. Okay. Okay. Okay. Yeah, definitely. The theme of water and it's a major point is, like, how people look at water after. Yeah. Like, for example, if. You lose a family member to drowning, how you could be more respectable of water or really hate it. Like, so that's what I explore through Lizzie's the three sisters and Amanda. Like, do you have questions or thoughts on that?

**CAMILLE THOMAS (10:28):** Yeah, one of the thoughts, something that resonated with me. I just thought it was such a strong decision, I forget who it might have been. Lizzie who chose to go the long way through Wisconsin to the UP Instead of crossing the bridge. I was like, dang, that. That's a big grief to be like, I'm gonna go all the way through Wisconsin instead of crossing that bridge. I thought that was such an effective choice to show, like, the things that she is grappling with.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (10:56):** That's helpful. Yeah. Bridge is such a. Yeah. A heavy metaphor of like. Yeah. And it's. Most bridge on earth has had a suicide happen. So everyone does see the real. I visited that bridge after, like, Andy's like, pass. Like, with some people. So I was like, oh, so it's definitely. Yeah. Crossing the bridge is my term of like, I am not moving on but confronting. And yeah. I guess, like, did did the build up. Was the build up pretty okay when it gets to that point in the climax where like. Oh, yeah. Originally, before I got this critical feedback of, like, fleshing out the villain idea, I. It wasn't like, actually helping the villain at all. I was kind of like, nah, she just get thrown in a mental institution in Traverse City. And then they're like, no. And I was like, okay, fine, fine. I'll dive deeper into Amanda is. And then I was like, okay, she lost her brother to suicide too. So. Yeah. Yeah. Yeah. I don't know. Yeah. If you thought, like, the climax was earned, like, okay, all this family member is going to help the person who stole their home, like, cross the bridge too.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (12:21):** Yeah. I don't remember having any big, like, negative thoughts on it, so I think it worked.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (12:26):** Okay. Okay. Okay. Yeah. Let's see, I put. I lacked the choice. Um, I honestly, it's like you can just write Detroit a musical, and it's like, not even enough in 90 minutes to encapsulate what Detroit is. So me trying to, like, put the culture of a

thousand townships, 300 cities in one is incredibly hard. But. And, yeah, like, Dearborn is the closest kind of identity I have that represents a bit of Detroit. But yeah. I was wondering what your thoughts as, like, a Detroiter.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (13:09):** Yeah, I didn't miss it. I know this is not like a Detroit story, so I wasn't looking for Detroit. I like some of the Michigan references, though. Like, page 28, I said I love the pizza debate. Very Michigan. So I don't even know if you could put, like, I don't remember what pizzas you named. Let me see if I go to page 28 and find it. But I was like, oh, maybe if you even put Detroit style pizza as like, a little Detroit drop. Maybe you did that. Let me see. Oh, no. Domino's. Yeah. You have Domino's. Hungry Howie's cottage in Buddy's Pizza. Yeah. So maybe even if you mentioned just. Oh, yeah, Detroit style, that could be a fun Detroit moment. But I wasn't offended or confused.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (13:50):** Yeah. I tried. I made reference to Detroit style. Banh Mi.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (13:55):** Yeah.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (13:55):** Which is totally made up. Yeah. Like, okay, so. So food at least is something that encapsulates culture really well. Yeah.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (14:08):** And also because they. They. The parade, the costume parade, they're all in a bunch of different cars. Detroit being Motown Motor City, there could be some kind of like, oh, my God. And this is a model Ford. Like, the Ford headquarters is in Detroit or whatever kind of car reference could fit in there.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (14:24):** Okay. Cars. The reference. Yeah. Because it's just the model T. Really. That's the main reference. And that's because a lot of this is based on Lucas family too. Yeah. Which is hilarious. Like, yeah, like, the dynamics, the three sisters, which the real people are named Carrie, Bonnie, and Julie. So it was fun being like Sherry, Perry, and Shelby, which are real townships in Michigan.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (14:54):** Yes. Okay, that's funny. I didn't know they were named after townships. I didn't catch that because I know Shelby Township, but I don't know Perry and Sherry. So that's fun.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (15:04):** Yes. Okay. Okay. Yeah. Okay. Detroit's. Yeah. If. If you ever want to write Detroit the musical, let me know.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (15:11):** I will. I definitely will.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (15:14):** Let's see. Okay. Okay. Yeah, yeah, yeah. Let's see. And then. Okay, good. Yeah, go on.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (15:25):** Mm. A point of clarity for me. Page 77. So I finally understood it at the end. But in my note, I said, a house for an artificial soul. I think that level of clarity can come earlier, especially because it's such an eerie thought. What will you trade to see your loved one again? Your house, your soul for a data center that can bring them back through the power of AI. I think I wasn't clear, 100% clear on what Amanda was offering when she was like, ooh, your loved one. I didn't. It didn't come clear to me until page 77. And I thought that clarity could be maybe sooner because it is such a big, scary, eerie thought of like, oh my God, I get to see my loved one, but what do I trade for them?

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (16:08):** Yeah, I'll clear that up more. Yeah, I definitely was probably worth playing a lot there too. Yeah, yeah. Amanda is just. I guess Amanda's intention, of course. Okay, so chronologically, okay. She and her brother, very techie people. But she really went to art school. He went to and started the startup. And then during recession, he commits suicide. She becomes very. Yeah, hates water.

She was a watercolor artist, which I could read even deeper about, which is ironic. Yeah, yeah, yeah. And then she of course starts hating water, starts doing Photoshop, gets expelled, like for not doing her more hands on work anymore. She goes and pushes AI forward. Starts after afterlife AI, which is an avatar software. AI. Dang that, bruh. Yeah, yeah, yeah. Like any deceased one in with footages on the Internet or whatever, she's able to extract that. And I. I know it's like surrealism. Yeah. Like when people pop up in the physical form. I mean, if it was like filmed, it's like, well, it's on a tablet, but. Yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah. She fools a bunch of old people throughout the state constantly to sell their homes by offering a trade of their deed for.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (17:48):** For their AI avatar family member.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (17:51):** Yes, yes, yeah, yes. And her also her tensions with building more data centers. Her brother gets more realer to her too. She uses that.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (18:00):** Oh, does she have an AI clone of her brother?

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (18:03):** Yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah. Okay. That might help actually, a lot. Yeah, yeah, yeah.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (18:07):** I was gonna say, was that in there the AI clone of her brother?

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (18:10):** No, I. I have a hard time trying to be like one more character. Yeah, yeah, that's a producer. But I'm like. Because, yeah, I'm just like silhouette of Connor or like. Yeah, but I have avatars of Connor. Not good. Yeah. Help like. Oh man. If a production uses AI, I'm Freaking out. But, like, anyway, don't do that. Figure. Figure out how

to pretend you're using AI. So. Yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah. Her attention, of course, is the more she. More data she center she's built, the more realistic these AI avatars become.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (18:49):** AI brother becomes. That's so interesting. Oh, cool.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (18:51):** Yeah. Yeah. Okay. That helps help us. Okay. Okay.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (18:56):** Yeah. Because I think that just gives her a stronger intention of. Or intention objective of. Like, yes, I do hate water because my brother killed himself in it. And also, the more water I take and build these data centers, the more real my brother can become. Just gives her, like, a stronger lift.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (19:13):** Oh, my gosh. Yes. Okay, that's clear. And I mean, I don't have to really metaphor allegorize it. I'm going to be. I could be pretty blunt.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (19:21):** Yeah.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (19:22):** Like.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (19:22):** And maybe he doesn't need to be a whole character. It could just be her saying it. Yeah, whatever works for your process, you know?

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (19:29):** Yeah, it's. And the bridge is of what you say, a duality between spirituality and, like, technology. So, yeah, she throws out her phone to.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (19:45):** See.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (19:47):** See her brother in spirit form. Let's say again metaphorically.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (19:50):** Yeah, yeah.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (19:55):** Yeah. But in the end, I do. I do, like, show that she, like, gets into governments and is she still corrupt? Yeah.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (20:09):** Let's see.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (20:09):** Okay. Other points of clarity.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (20:14):** No, I think those were my big points of clarity, I guess. How do you imagine that Connor paved the way for AI art?

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (20:23):** How do I imagine.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (20:24):** Sorry. Page 49, scene 8. Let me see if there was that. I was like, what am I asking about?

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (20:31):** Okay, so good, I'll do. I clarify Connors. Okay. Oh, take care. Thank you so much. Okay. I don't know yet quite yet, but I'll figure it out. Let's see. Maybe. Okay.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (20:49):** But that was it. Those were the only things, I guess. The bridge thing, it reminded me of Hayao Miyazaki's movie Spirited Away. They have to hold their breath when they breath when they cross the bridge, or else the spirits will see them. So that was an interesting thought to have as I was reading your show Breath. You see him.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (21:06):** Okay. Yeah. This could be a very expensive show to try, but, no, I don't think that way. Yeah. The last things I could think about is, like, any collaborators you would recommend.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (21:25):** Orbit?

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (21:27):** Yeah, yeah. Helping. Especially demos, too.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (21:30):** Mm, no, I'm not. I don't know a lot of musical theater people. No, I'm so sorry, David. All I got is I got to recommend Cece for lighting. But as far as singers and musicals, that is not my bag at all. Okay, maybe what's his name? Let me look him up. I know he works on musicals. He's a friend's boyfriend and I'm trying to remember. The friend's name is Tajane. And his name? Antonio. Let me find this. I'll type in his Instagram. I'll. Antonio. I wonder if he has a website. This is his Insta Instagram. He's also pretty busy, like, with his own musicals and things. And maybe my friend Lissandra, she might be open to helping or at least talking more. I'll send you her Instagram as well. Sorry. Let me find it. So I sent Antonio's in the chat. Is it easier if I text them to you or do you want me to just drop them in the chat?

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (24:54):** Yeah, you can drop in the chat or the way you type into your. Well, either. It's fine.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (22:59):** Okay. And this is Lissandra's Instagram. I'll text it since I'm already on my phone. Yeah, Lissandra works on musicals as well.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (23:11):** Okay.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (23:13):** And maybe Xander. Have you ever worked with Xander before? You know Xander? Yeah. Maybe I'll send.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (23:20):** Oh, wait, wait. Okay, let's just send it. Yeah.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (23:34):** Yeah, I'd say those are three people that you can check out.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (23:39):** All right. Yeah, I'll ask how their connections with Michigan's great. Okay. Okay. Because, yeah, I'm gonna folksy and Motown and gospel. It's an extreme.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (23:55):** Yeah, yeah, yeah.

**DAVID QUANG PHAM (23:58):** Okay. This is great. Yeah, yeah. I have. And I wish you all the best in grad school applications. Yeah, yeah, yeah, I know. I was like, happy to ask you first to be a book writer because I'm like. I don't know if anything works at all. But, like, feel free to. Yeah. If you want. I would be down for you to write a song or two or anything if you want to ever collaborate, so. Because I would be happy to put a bunch of list of friends who have help develop it.

**CAMILLE THOMAS (24:31):** Yeah. Do you have any songs in mind? Just like, I like the Water song that you sent a lot, but I also cannot commit to anything. This is me talking to myself, being like. I. Frequently. I'm trying not to over commit, so, you know, don't hold me to it. I'm going to say no. This is me being firm with myself, actually.